

**SHOW OF FORCE**
US president Donald Trump, Defense Secretary Pete Hegseth and Chairman of the Joint Chiefs of Staff Gen. Dan Caine, Washington D.C., Apr. 6

REUTERS

**THE US AND ISRAEL ARE UNLIKELY TO TOPPLE IRAN'S THEOCRACY. IF ANYTHING, THE HARDLINERS ARE MORE IN CONTROL AND AMERICA'S ALLIES IN THE GULF FACE A DEEPLY WOUNDED AND VENGEFUL IRAN**

Republic into being, the threat became existential, drawing the GCC ever closer to the US. In 2008, King Abdullah of Saudi Arabia famously urged a senior American visitor that Washington needed to "cut off the head of the snake," a direct appeal for regime change in Tehran.

Notwithstanding King Abdullah's plea and Trump's preposterous claims that regime change has already occurred, it does not currently appear that the US and Israel will in fact be able to topple the Iranian theocracy. If anything, the hardliners are more in control and the wished-for uprising by the long-oppressed Iranian people seems ever further from reach. America's allies in the Gulf now face the prospect of a deeply wounded and vengeful Iran, with the GCC states as the nearest targets for retribution.

## THE WAY AHEAD

Equally essential for the economic prosperity of the Gulf states will be the shape of the agreement on the reopening of the Strait of Hormuz. Any outcome that does not fully restore the freedom of navigation in this vital waterway will further imperil the economies of the Gulf region, already reeling from the sustained damage to their vital infrastructure (desalination plants, civilian installations and petrochemical facilities) inflicted by Iranian strikes. The impact of the Strait's closure has been felt well beyond this narrow body of water, and the quicker it is reopened the easier it will be for the GCC to resume their diverse exports, which now comprise the critical components for a global supply chain that feeds billions of people. Trump abdicating responsibility for reopening the Strait has provided an opportunity for others, including the Chinese, Japanese and Europeans, to broker a solution—which is now possible given the suspension of hostilities. Ironically, though, one outcome could see a consolidation of Iranian control over the Strait, either using the 'toll booth' model or simply because the regime has demonstrated its ability to close the waterway at will.

In the short term, it is likely that the GCC states will remain closely tied to the United States. Already, their US-supplied defence stocks—including the expensive interceptors they are using to down cheaper Iranian drones—are running low and will need to be quickly replenished. Especially if the Iranian regime remains in place, the Gulf states will need to continue to rely on hosting tens of thousands of US military personnel. With Israel's wanton destruction of Gaza (which roiled public opinion in the Gulf) in the rearview mirror and its current invasion and ethnic cleansing of south Lebanon decidedly a sideshow for Gulf leaders, normalisation of ties between Israel and the Gulf states (beyond Bahrain and the UAE, who have already joined the Abraham Accords) is possible.

With an agreement reached on a temporary ceasefire, can we say that we are at the end of the beginning or the beginning of the end of the US-Israeli war on Iran? The answer to that question will have profound consequences not only for the future of the Gulf states, but also for regional peace and security and the global economy. Yet this continued uncertainty cannot obscure or excuse the enormous loss of life, physical destruction and existential peril this unnecessary and senseless conflict has already caused. ■